predator, though it was ‘eager . . . [and] swift as the wind’. A second cheetah was unleashed; this one broke the deer’s neck. No matter, said Akbar. It only meant that Daud would escape Akbar once, but fall to his generals later.

It happened exactly so.

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The siege of Patna had begun in the winter of 1573. When Akbar arrived, on 4 August 1574, it had been going on for at least eight months. Partly this was because the Mughals had focused their forces on Patna, while the city was supplied with provisions from Hajipur, across the river.

Akbar expanded the siege to two fronts, Patna and Hajipur, fought it on two levels, strategic and psychological, and won it in two days. This is what happened.

By Akbar’s orders, Munim Khan arranged an intimidating display of fireworks to greet him, filling the air with smoke and thunder, turning it as ‘dark as the fortunes of the enemies . . . The horrific noise wound its way into the brains of the darkened foe’, Abul Fazl writes, ‘and their gall-bladders became as water’. Indeed, his ‘liver-less soul upset’, Daud prayed for peace the very next day. Akbar refused. Like a cheetah toying with its prey, he offered his luckless enemy three choices: one-to-one combat between Akbar and Daud, between their nominees, or between their elephants.

Meanwhile, Akbar also sent 3000 men on a night attack upon Hajipur. This was no covert operation executed in dark secrecy. As Badauni describes it, the 3000 soldiers were all cavalry, and they were sent out ‘fully equipped . . . in boats with such ornamentation and display, that at the sight of it the eye was rejoiced’. Not, of course, the eyes watching from Hajipur. The enemy garrison ‘fell into the whirlpool of anxiety’, writes Abul Fazl; Hajipur fell that very night and the boats returned to Akbar, loaded with enemy heads.

Akbar sent the grisly trophies to Daud, who was ‘plunged into dismay’ at the sight and ‘set his mind upon flight’.[27] Thus, on 6 August, only two days after the shahinshah’s dramatic entrance into the fray, Daud fled the city, ‘in a swift boat’ from a wicket gate, leaving a stampede in his wake. The